Edit article
View stats
View post

NCPDP: Ensuring the Heartbeat of Healthcare is strong

Kelee Petzelt
Advocate for Change | Driving AI to Empower Pharmacists as Healthcare Leaders | Transforming Patient Care with a Focus...

September 16, 2024

NCPDP (National Council for Prescription Drug Programs, Inc.) , under the visionary leadership of LeeAnn Stember and her team, has always understood that healthcare is not just about moving data—it's about **moving people**. It's about connecting pharmacists with the information they need to make critical decisions, ensuring patients receive the right care at the right time, and empowering the entire healthcare ecosystem to function like a well-coordinated body. In this vision, pharmacies are the **heart of healthcare**, and NCPDP is the **veins**—pumping the vital flow of data that sustains and strengthens patient care.

Healthcare is personal. Behind every data point and prescription is a human life depending on the system we create. NCPDP's role has been to ensure that the **data flow**—the "blood" of healthcare—reaches every corner, empowering pharmacists to not only dispense medications but to improve outcomes, prevent errors, and enhance overall care.

In today's rapidly evolving healthcare landscape, **value-based care** is the future. The outdated fee-for-service model has disconnected the heart of healthcare from the rest of the system, leading to inefficiencies and lost opportunities for better patient outcomes. NCPDP, however, offers the foundation that reconnects these systems, ensuring that data flows seamlessly between prescribers, pharmacies, and payers.

This is the **human network** working together—a network of experts who are, at their core, people. They care about the patients they serve and understand that **healthcare needs to be human**. Without this humanity,

we risk losing the heart of what makes healthcare tick. It is by building on this personal, human-centered foundation that we ensure the heart of healthcare remains healthy.

If we don't make healthcare human, we'll remain stuck in the inefficiencies and barriers we face today. **Healthcare needs to be value-based**, centered on the well-being of people, and powered by data that enhances patient care. NCPDP has created the infrastructure—the **circulatory system**—that allows this to happen. Through its standards and systems, NCPDP enables the pharmacist - **the heartbeat of healthcare -** to remain steady and strong.

I always thought I didn't belong at NCPDP before I understood it. I am no technical genius by any stretch, and that often gets overlooked when we hear NCPDP—but NCPDP is so much more than technical. It brings together all parts of the body, working in harmony, and has mastered this in a way that other standards organizations could stop and learn from. It may not be the biggest, but the focus, intent, and value of what comes out of NCPDP is truly worth it. It's not just about technical standards; it's about ensuring the entire healthcare system works in harmony.

Pharmacies, as the heart of care delivery, thrive when they're integrated into a broader ecosystem where data flows efficiently, accurately, and with purpose. By prioritizing human connection and enabling real-time data exchange, NCPDP ensures that pharmacists have the tools to meet quality measures, participate in value-based care, and deliver more personalized patient care.

Here's the key difference: **NCPDP, as the circulatory system, enhances and complements the other standards organizations.** While groups like HL7, X12, and others provide the framework for clinical and administrative data exchange, NCPDP ensures that pharmacy and medication-related data flows seamlessly through the system. It doesn't compete with these organizations; it **strengthens** them. By making sure that pharmacy is not overlooked, NCPDP is making healthcare more complete, more connected, and more capable of providing the best outcomes for patients.

This powerful analogy of NCPDP as the veins circulating lifeblood to the heart of healthcare should resonate with all members—pharmacists, healthcare leaders, and those yet to be involved. It reminds us that the future of healthcare is not just about advancing technology; it's about ensuring that every **human element** of the system works together to create a healthier, more compassionate world.

NCPDP has laid the foundation for this future. If the heart of healthcare is strong, every other part of the system can function at its best. The **blood flow of data** that NCPDP enables will ensure that pharmacists and the broader healthcare system can grow, thrive, and deliver the kind of care patients deserve—care that's both **human and efficient**, data-driven yet deeply personal. Together, we can ensure that the **heartbeat of healthcare** is healthy, allowing the entire system to function, thrive, and provide the best possible outcomes for everyone.

Kelee Petzelt

Advocate for Change | Driving AI to Empower Pharmacists as Healthcare Leaders | Transforming Patient Care with a Focus on the Future | Champion for Patient-Centered Innovation and Precision Medicine

More articles for you

Published on LinkedIn

Asembia 2018: The Call for Coordinated Care is Loud and Clear

Randall Maloziec

27 · 1 comment

E-Prescription and Its Effect on Reducing Healthcare Costs

MyRx

13 Acronyms to Understanding Real-World Data and Evidence in Healthcare

Ashish Patel

46